



Figure 4: OpenOffice 3.2.1

Debian is known for its extremely long installation procedure (something to the tune of 23-26 steps, depending on the installation method). While it's pretty long, it's not at all complex. In fact, it's very simple and self-explanatory, and anyone even vaguely familiar with Linux should be able to install the system. I will, therefore, spare you an installation how-to, and speak more about the installer itself.

The first thing that will strike you when the installer boots is the artwork. SpaceFun now flaunts itself from the installer itself. I selected British English language, US key-map and Indian locale settings, which automatically showed me only Indian mirrors in the mirror selection screen. I opted to use IIT Kharagpur's mirror since it's the closest to me, but IIT Madras' mirror should be faster. The third and last option is Debian's CDN, which fetches from many load-balanced servers simultaneously. I didn't use it, since there's a possibility of package conflicts between different mirrors.

I'd given the VM a 20 GB dedicated SCSI hard drive, so I let Debian do automatic partitioning. I was surprised to note that Debian still uses the ext3 file-system. I'd recommend using ext4—the performance gains are significant. And ext4 is well supported in kernel 2.6.32; no data-loss bugs to be scared about.

The installation took about five hours at my end, out of which all but 15 minutes was spent downloading packages over a 512 KBps Internet connection. And then... kaboom! Apparently, the Internet connection had packed up for a couple of seconds, preventing a couple of packages from downloading. Rather than retrying the download, Debian-Installer silently failed, leading to a botched installation.

I re-downloaded CD 1 of the 52-CD set and re-ran the install using that, but the installer still took three hours to download updated packages, this time from IIT Madras' mirror.

The desktop

Apart from the pretty staple GNOME 2.30 desktop with OpenOffice.org 3.2.1 (see Figure 4), nothing much is quite worth mentioning, since everything is so stock

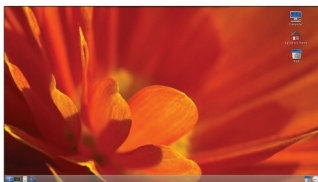


Figure 5: Docky in Debian, showing off Metacity compositing

and commonplace. Debian still refuses to enable LCD sub-pixel rendering patches, even though the FreeType patent expired aeons ago. Otherwise, the system is pretty responsive.

Something that frustrates me is the lack of up-to-date Web browsers. Chromium is at version 6, Firefox (no, their IceWeasel crap) is at version 3.5.12 (because of feuds with Mozilla, apparently), and IceDove (Thunderbird) is at 3.0.11 (3.1.7 is available in experimental mode, as of this writing). I had to download Google Chrome directly from its website to get an up-to-date tool to browse the Web. This is unacceptable in the world of GNU/Linux. You should not need to manually download a Web browser—c'mon, who does that?

I wasn't able to test out Compiz because: a) it isn't installed by default, and I'm a very lazy person; and b) I had trouble getting 3D acceleration in VMWare Linux guests to work. This is a driver issue solved by the new KMS-capable *vmwgfx* driver—which, again, isn't included in Debian Squeeze, because it's too darned new! However, I did enable Metacity's compositing, and the drop-shadows were pleasing to the eye. I also went ahead and installed Docky, to test if translucency was working with Metacity compositing—it was (see Figure 5).

One bizarre bug I faced concerns enabling sub-pixel rendering. I right-clicked the desktop, went into *Change Desktop Background*, switched to the *Fonts* tab, and selected the *Sub-pixel Rendering* radio button. At once the font size jumped to something like 20 pixels, but strangely, the font selectors all showed 10 pixels. I manually changed all font sizes to 6, and got 9-pixel fonts. I was pretty baffled by this behaviour.

Now Debian is light enough to work very well on older hardware, but it does include LXDE and XFCE for people who'd like them. Something worth mentioning is that LXDE is at version 0.5.0, which, although admittedly 13 months old, is still the latest available! XFCE is at version 4.6.2 (4.8 was released a couple of weeks ago).

I did have some trouble adjusting to Debian, having been used to Ubuntu for such a long time. For starters, Debian does not include support for indicators, and